

Mosasaur

Just before the end of the Cretaceous Period, the seas were home to gigantic lizards as terrifying and as huge as any mythological sea serpent. Called mosasaurs, these monsters were close relatives of today's lizards and snakes. They evolved from small, land-living lizards that took to the water in search of food. As the lizards adapted to life in the sea, their legs turned into flippers and their bodies, supported by water, became enormous.

Mosasaurus

MOSE-ah-saw-rus



- **When** 70–65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA, Belgium, Japan, Netherlands, New Zealand, Morocco, Turkey
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** About 50 ft (15 m)
- **Diet** Fish, squid, and shellfish

Mosasaurus was one of the largest mosasaurs. It looked a bit like a crocodile with flippers, and swam by moving its long body in slow waves. As a result, it couldn't swim fast over long distances, but might have been capable of sudden bursts of speed. Scientists think *Mosasaurus* lived in the well-lit surface waters of oceans, hunting slower-moving prey. Bite marks left by its huge, conical teeth have been found on turtle shells and ammonites. *Mosasaurus* survived to the end of the Cretaceous, when it vanished with the dinosaurs.